

fridayReview

THE HINDU

On a composer’s trail

A new play by Bombay Gnanam’s all-women troupe portrays Purandaradasa’s life **p2**

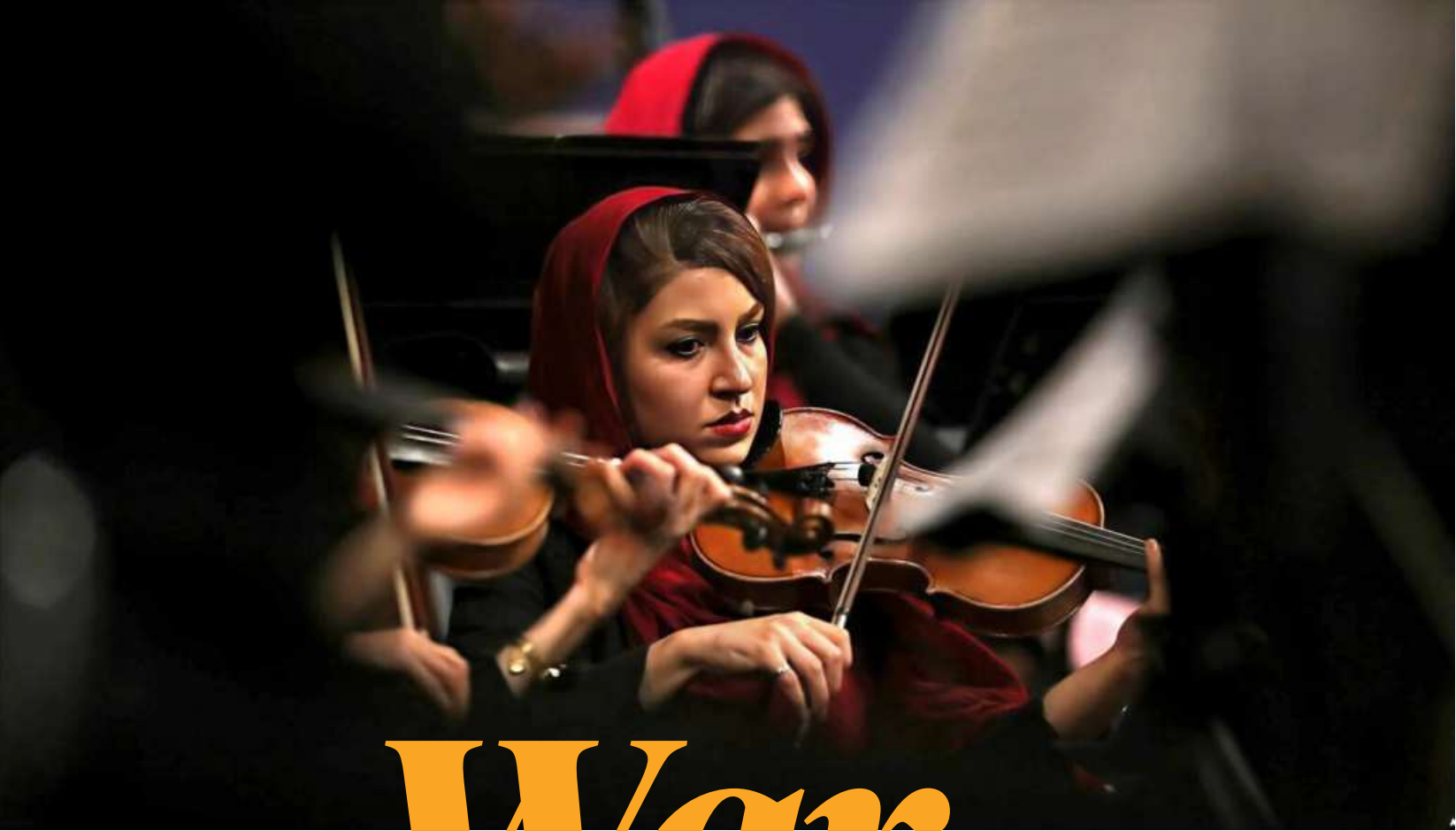
Born in 1947, still going strong

Why the Shankarlal Music Festival stands out on India’s cultural calendar **p3**



AMOL PALEKAR: A LIFE IN ART

The actor-director has been honoured with the META Lifetime Achievement Award **p4**



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Even as Operation Epic Fury, a joint U.S.-Israel military campaign against Iran, shows no sign of letting up, another ‘Epic’ has suddenly experienced a surge in popularity. The ‘Epic of Khorramshahr’, which has been trending on social media, particularly Instagram, from early this year, is a monumental symphonic work by Majid Entezami, one of Iran’s most influential contemporary composers. Not just the original composition, but even its remixes are being widely shared.

Entezami crafted this work with sweeping passages of haunting rhythms, powerful melodies and dramatic crescendos in 1982, to commemorate Iran’s liberation after the Iran-Iraq war. He musically chronicled the huge loss of lives and devastation, as well as sacrifices and the spirit of survival in Khorramshahr, a city on the Iran-Iraq border. Because of its narrative quality, the composition is often referred to as a ‘symphony of storytelling’. First conducted by Entezami himself and performed by the Tehran Symphony Orchestra, ‘Epic of Khorramshahr’ was structured in four movements – *Uruj* (ascension), *Ruyesh* (flourishing), *Omid* (hope) and *Mukavemet* (resistance).

Forty-four years after it was composed, this music re-emerged

War and Piece

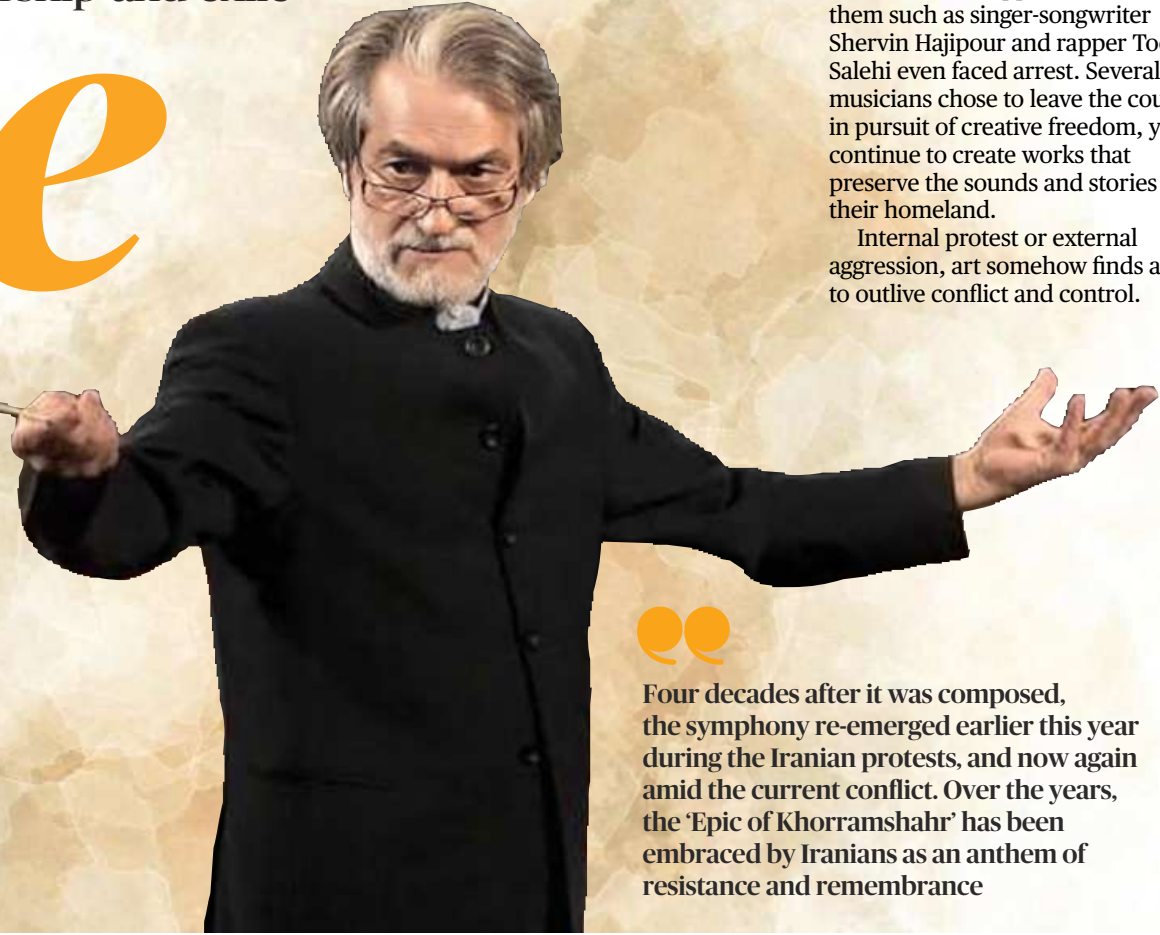
As Majid Entezami’s 44-year-old symphonic work ‘Epic of Khorramshahr’ resurfaces online, it highlights Iranian music’s long struggle to endure conflict, censorship and exile

earlier this year during the Iranian protests, and now again amid the current conflict. Over the years, the ‘Epic of Khorramshahr’ has been embraced by Iranians as an anthem of resistance and remembrance. An Instagram post by @museumartof, an independent digital art and museum curation platform, describes it as “the grand scale of history through sound and a pillar of modern classical compositions”. The post adds that “the most enduring monuments are often built not of stone, but of melody, conviction and collective memory”.

Apart from creating over 10 deeply evocative suite symphonies, in which Entezami seamlessly blends Iranian mythology and musical

elements with western symphonic techniques, he has also composed scores for nearly 80 films including *The Cyclist*, *The Glass Agency*, *The Fateful Day* and *From Kharkkeh to Rhine*. One reason his works are being revisited and widely discussed today is that, in times of conflict, people often seek refuge in art and its healing power. This renewed attention also reflects a deeper truth: one of the most devastating fallout of war is cultural disruption.

Iran’s Golestan Palace, a UNESCO world heritage site, has been severely damaged, while galleries, museums and other cultural venues have closed their doors. While Iran is globally known for its vast oil



Four decades after it was composed, the symphony re-emerged earlier this year during the Iranian protests, and now again amid the current conflict. Over the years, the ‘Epic of Khorramshahr’ has been embraced by Iranians as an anthem of resistance and remembrance

Nagaswaram takes centre stage

The Music Academy’s Nadotsavam will be held from March 23 to 25

The third edition of The Music Academy’s nagaswaram festival ‘Nadotsavam 2026’ is back with an array of concerts by up-and-coming artists and senior musicians. To be held from March 23 to 25 at the Kasturi Srinivasan Hall, it will feature two concerts each daily – 5.15 p.m. and 7 p.m.

The festival was launched with an aim to offer a dedicated space to celebrate the nagaswaram, which was once played only in temples and on auspicious occasions. By bringing the nagaswaram artistes to the proscenium stage, the festival attempts to honour the legacy of past practitioners while opening new avenues.

This year’s festival begins with the nagaswaram performance by Tirupananthal Viswanathan and Vijayalakshmi with Achalpuram



Tradition ‘n’ harmony Pazhayaseevaram G. Kalidass and Koleri G. Vinoth Kumar. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

A.V. Selvam and Tiruvenkadu T.M. Guhan on the thavil at 5.15 p.m. This will be followed by Guruvilli Appanna Rao’s performance with Guruvilli

Durga Rao and Cuddapah D.V. Ramasubbiah on the thavil at 7 p.m. Thirumanur brothers – T.K. Karthikeyan and T.K.

Kameshwaran – will perform on March 24 at 5.15 p.m. Mandaveli S. Mohanraj and Mayiladuthurai SRDM B. Muthukumar will accompany them on the thavil.

This will be followed by Sembanarkoil S.R.G.S. Mohandoss and Mylai K. Selvam’s recital at 7 p.m. Swamimalai C. Gurunathan and Sivanvoyal S.M. Rajarathinam will accompany on the thavil.

Artistes to perform on March 25 are: 5.15 p.m.: Pazhayaseevaram G. Kalidass and Koleri G. Vinoth Kumar (nagaswaram) with Tirukkadaiyur T.G. Babu and Panapakkam G. Tamizhselvan (thavil) and 7 p.m.: Vadassery Brothers – T. Sethumadhavan and TV. Sivadasan (nagaswaram) with Pollachi S. Sivasankar and Poondi T.G. Udaya Shankar on the thavil.

CULTUREBRIEFS

Musical ode to Dikshitar



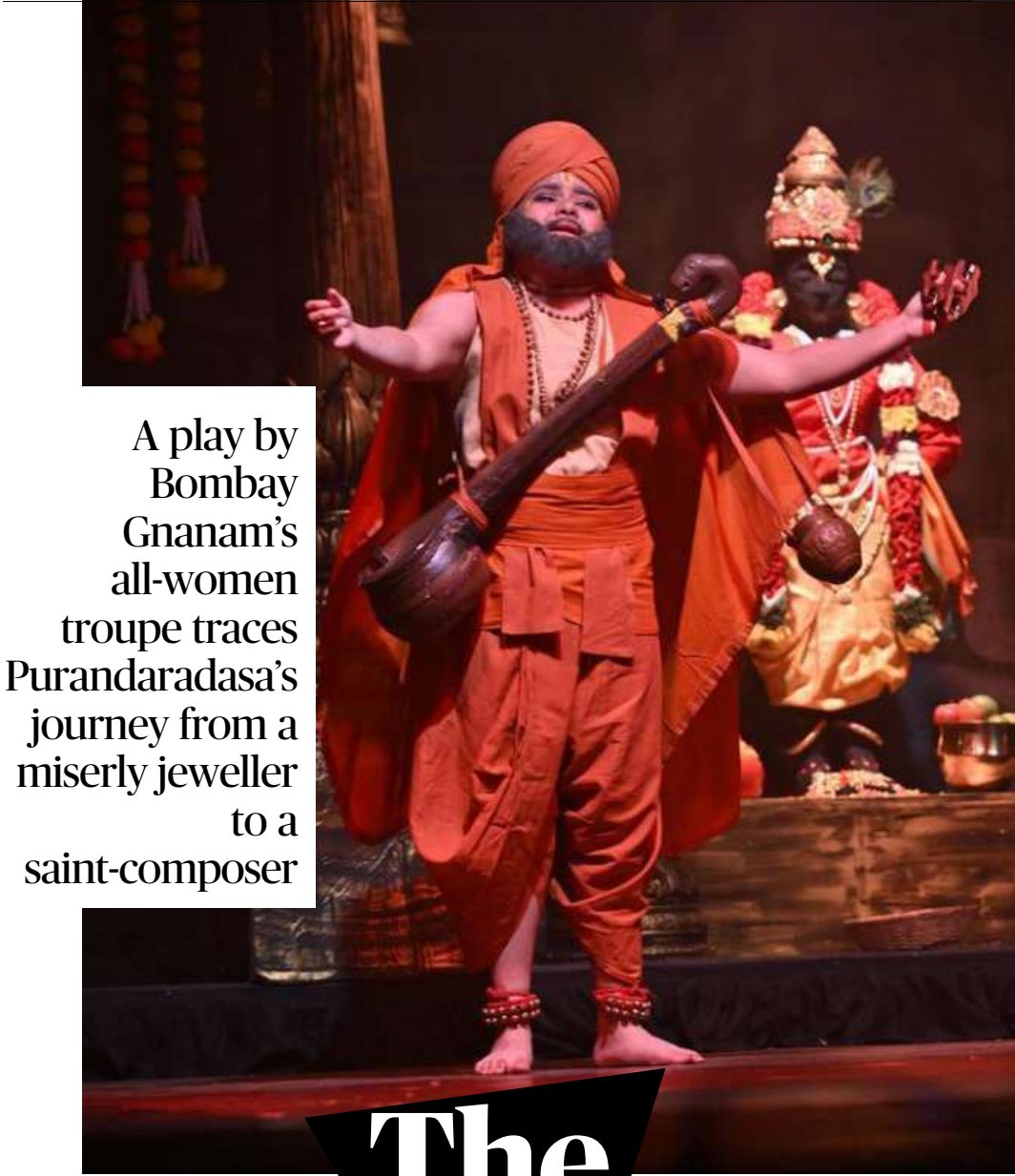
Guruguhaamrta, helmed by Carnatic vocalist G. Ravi Kiran, will feature a special concert to mark the birth anniversary of Muthuswami Dikshitar on March 24, at 6 p.m. Vainikas Jeyaraaj and Jaysri Jeyaraaj will present a thematic concert which will

feature kritis on Tiruvurur composed by Dikshitar. K. Arun Prakash (mridangam) and Trichy Murali (ghatam) will accompany them. The concert will be preceded by the launch of the new episode of ‘Dikshitar Kshetra Darshanam’. This time the focus is on Tiruvurur, the birthplace of Muthuswami Dikshitar. R. Seshasayee, the guest of honour, will launch the episode. Venue: Ragasudha Hall, Luz, Mylapore.



Thematic production

Kalakshetra Foundations’ next edition of Kala Mela features ‘Shishiram – A prelude to the blossoming’, a thematic Bharatanatyam performance by Nidheesh and Indhu Nidheesh on March 21 at Rukmini Arangam. Time: 6 p.m.



A play by Bombay Gnanam’s all-women troupe traces Purandaradasa’s journey from a miserly jeweller to a saint-composer

Aishwarya Raghunathan

Long before the saint-composer came to be venerated as Purandaradasa (also known as Sangeetha Pitamaha), he was known as Srinivasa Nayaka – a prosperous jeweller from Purandara Gada near Hampi in the 14th century. Popularly called Seenappa, he inherited and expanded a thriving gem and jewellery business, amassing immense wealth. Yet, along with the prosperity came a reputation for extreme miserliness; charity found little place, and devotion even less.

The story in song

The turning point in his life came through a divine encounter. An old mendicant repeatedly approached Seenappa at his shop seeking alms but was refused each time. After months of persistence, the jeweller finally

drove him away in anger. The mendicant then went to Seenappa’s house, where his wife Saraswathi Bai, moved by compassion, offered him her nose ring. Soon after, the same ornament appeared in Seenappa’s shop when the

Divine sojourn The play *Sri Bhagawan Panduranganin Purandaradasar*.
PHOTO: M. SRINATH

mysterious visitor, disguised as a wealthy man, attempted to sell it to him.

A chain of miraculous events followed, revealing the visitor to be none other than Lord Vittala himself in disguise. Overwhelmed with remorse, Seenappa renounced his riches and embraced the path of devotion, under the guidance of guru Vyasaraya, taking the name of Purandaradasa.

His life, after this transformation, became one of intense devotion and musical outpouring. Purandaradasa is credited with systematising the basic lessons of Carnatic music, laying out the graded exercises that beginners still follow. Tradition attributes an astonishing 4,75,000 compositions to him. His son, Madhvapathi, is said to have composed another 25,000, bringing the family’s devotional corpus to nearly five lakh songs.

Within the Haridasa tradition, it is believed that Purandaradasa was an incarnation of sage Narada – born to remind the world that wealth is not life’s ultimate pursuit.

This remarkable life story found a theatrical expression in *Sri Bhagawan Panduranganin Purandaradasar*, presented by Bombay Gnanam’s Arts Academy – an all-women drama troupe.

Featuring 14 performers, with many donning multiple roles, the production drew on *Karnataka Bhakta Vijaya* and references from Harikatha exponent, Vishaka Hari.

The play flowed seamlessly without blackouts, aided by Mohan Babu’s lighting design – red for interiors, yellow for outdoor scenes, and blue for night or celestial moments. The production design was equally detailed: Seenappa’s shop

displayed jewellery-filled lockers and old ledgers, while the domestic space featured silver vessels in the puja room, lending authenticity to the period setting.

Even subtle details – such as sandalwood paste smeared on the hands of the elderly Purandaradasa – revealed the care invested in the visual storytelling.

Costumes were carefully referenced to reflect the period setting, with jewellery ranging from gem-studded rings to armlets. Even smaller characters – soldiers, attendants and servants – were performed with commitment.

An interesting casting decision added another layer of continuity to the narrative. The role of the elderly Purandaradasa was played by an 18-year-old performer, while the younger Seenappa was portrayed by her mother. Their natural resemblance lent credibility to the transition between the two stages of the character.

All the performers, based in Chennai, spent four months preparing for the production, which also marked the stage debut for some artistes.

Music formed the emotional core of the production. Familiar compositions such as ‘Venkatachala nilayam’, ‘Jagadodharana’ and ‘Tamboori meetidava’ were interwoven with lesser-heard pieces such as ‘Krishnamurthy’ (said to be the first song composed by Purandaradasa), ‘Kunidado krishna’, ‘Ninna bhagya doddadho’ and ‘Aparadhi nanalla’.

As the title of the play suggests, Lord Vittala repeatedly appears in the narrative to guide the errant jeweller towards transformation.

The response by the audience was enthusiastic, with many singing along. It was wonderful to revisit the life of a composer whose works have enriched the Carnatic repertoire and continue to stir rasikas.

CALENDAR



Remembering the Ustad

Kiran Nadar Museum of Art (KNMA) presents ‘Ustad Zakir Hussain: The Way Forward’, a three-day festival, celebrating the enduring legacy of the tabla maestro. To be held from March 27 to 29 at Sunder Nursery, New Delhi, the festival, conceptualised by MT Aditya Srinivasan (a recording and live sound engineer) brings together music, film, photography and conversation. Each evening will feature performances curated by three of his close collaborators – Yogesh Samsi, Ranjit Barot and Anantha R. Krishnan.

March 27, 5.30 p.m.: begins with Shradhdhanjali ; followed by a talk by Dayanita Singh – Travelling with Zakir Hussain (6 p.m.) and a photography exhibition by her, capturing candid moments of the musician. At 7 p.m. ‘Taal Vandana’, curated by Pt. Yogesh Samsi, which features him along with Aman Hussain, Garima Arya, Shravan Samsi, Shubham Ugale, Yashwant Thitte and Yashwant Vaishnav.

March 28, 5 p.m.: Screening of a film by Ustad’s daughter Anisa Qureshi ; followed by ‘Stories of Zakir’ – a talk by Mujeeb Dadarkar . At 7 p.m. ‘Saaz by Chitrahaar Live’, led by Pavithra Chari will highlight the Ustad’s contribution to Indian cinema.

March 29 (5 p.m.): Screening of the film *The Speaking Hand* by Sumantra Ghosal, followed by Q&A session. At 7 p.m. ‘Mellow Rhythms’, curated by Anantha R. Krishnan with Charumathi Raghuraman, Ramana Balachandhran, J.B. Sruthi Sagar, Rahul Vanamali and a Bharatanatyam performance by Shobana Chandrakumar.

Talking about the festival, Kiran Nadar, founder and chairperson, says: “This festival brings together some of Zakir Saab’s closest collaborators to reflect on the many dimensions of his legacy. For the Kiran Nadar Museum of Art, it also reflects our effort to create deeper dialogues between the visual and performing arts as we look towards our future space.”

Tickets for the festival on Skillbox

Consecration

The jeernodharana ashtabandhana mahakumbabishekam of Sri Varasiddhi Vinayagar Sri Panchamukha Anjaneyar temple, Pazhaniappa Nagar, Gowrivakkam, will be performed on March 25, between 9.30 a.m. and 10.30 a.m. Special rituals preceding the consecration will be performed from March 22.

Ramanavami celebrations

Sri Ram Samaj’s 73rd year Ramanavami utsavam began yesterday at Ayodha Mandapam, West Mambalam. The nine-day festival, to conclude on March 27, will feature a discourse on *Valmiki Ramayanam* to be presented by Damal Ramakrishnan and Perundevi. Time: 7 p.m.

Srirama Bhajanai Mandiram will celebrate the 120th year Ramanavami at Kettavarampalayam village, near Polur, Tiruvannamalai district, from March 27 to April 5. Unchavritti bhajan, Veda parayanam, Ramayana parayanam and Divyaprabandham (7 a.m. to 12 noon); special archana along with daily rituals (10 a.m. to 12 noon); discourses (3 p.m.-6 p.m.) and Divya namasankirtanam (10 p.m.) have been organised as part of the 10-day festival. Sita kalyanam will be performed on April 3. The festival concludes on April 5 with Anjaneya utsavam.

Veena recital

The Music Academy will feature young veena artiste Saranya B. Mangal’s performance today, 6 p.m. at the Kasturi Srinivasan Hall. She will be accompanied by Aswini Srinivasan (mridangam) and R.A. Rohith (ghatam). The programme is organised under the endowment instituted by Rajamma and N. Gopalaswami, former Chief Election Commissioner, in memory of their grandmother Kanakam Raghavachari.

In a familiar format

‘Vrajam bhaje’ needs to move beyond the margam framework to lend freshness to the theme

V.V. Ramani

‘Vrajam Bhaje’, an ensemble work by Renjith Babu and Vijna Vasudevan, journeyed into the sacred space of Vraja, exploring the varied facets of Krishna as seen through the eyes of his playmates and the gopikas. The evening, at the annual Jharna festival, opened with the Narayana Tirtha composition ‘Madhava mamava deva’ in raga Nilambari. Performed by Vijna, the leisurely portrayal established the identity of Krishna – face, curly hair, the peacock feather and the pitambara that adorns him. Six dancers presented the next composition, a varnam ‘Chalamu jesina’ composed by M. Balamuralikrishna in raga Ramapriya, weaving episodes from Krishna’s life. Lack of variations in the group

choreography created moments of monotony.

The spirit of devotion continued with the Pahadi raga composition ‘Aaj aaye shyam mohana’ which was followed by the melodious Surdas bhajan – ‘Bhoojath shyam kaun tu gori’ – in raga Chandrakauns. Set to music and choreographed by Prof. C.V. Chandrasekhar, the Sringara piece by Renjith and Vijna was a lyrical ode to the Radha-Krishna love.

Can a presentation on Krishna be complete without the Holi celebration? So came a group piece, ‘Hori khelan ki chale kanhaiya’ in raga Desh.

Krishna has inspired performances across dance traditions, with familiar ideas and stories often highlighted. ‘Vrajam Bhaje’, a work-in-progress, needs to move beyond the conventional margam format and embrace more creative



Lyrical ode to Krishna ‘Vrajam Bhaje’ by Renjith and Vijna.
PHOTO: J. JOHAN SATHYADAS

ideation that brings freshness to the theme. As for the musical score, a little more variety could have enhanced the experience. Mithun Madhusoodanan provided vocal

support with Kiran R. Pai on the mridangam, Anantaraman Balaji on the violin and Sujith Naik on the flute. Nattuvangam was by Meghana Krishnan.

Remitha Satheesh

A new independent music video ‘Feel the Spark’ has crossed 1.4 million views on YouTube in less than 36 hours – an impressive feat for a Tamil literature-inspired song. Penned, composed and produced by Raleigh Rajan and sung by American pop singer Ciera Dumas, the track has struck a chord with global audiences by celebrating some of the greatest voices of modern Tamil literature.

Composer Raleigh Rajan’s earlier album ‘Sandham: Symphony Meets Classical Tamil’, created with the Durham Symphony, also earned international acclaim and entered the Top 10 on Amazon’s International Music category. Rajan draws inspiration from the wit and humanism of Mark Twain

and the musicality of the *Kamba Ramayanam* to Subramania Bharati’s *Oozhikuthu* and the philosophical and socially incisive works of modern Tamil writers Jayakanthan and Jeyamohan. Rajan’s film repertoire also includes the recent Malayalam musical *4 Seasons*.

‘Feel the Spark’ uses music to pay tribute to towering literary figures such as Pudhumaipithan (regarded as the pioneer of modern Tamil literature), Sundara Ramasamy, Jayakanthan and Ki. Rajanarayanan. Each of these writers played a transformative role in shaping Tamil literature, and the song introduces their ideas to a younger, international audience through a vibrant fusion of music, visuals and storytelling.

Released virtually as part

of a cultural initiative linked to the Living Tamil Literature Festival, scheduled to take place in New York on April 3 and 4.

The lyrics and visuals weave together social realism, rural life, philosophical introspection and human emotion – all of which defined the works of these writers. The track transforms literary appreciation into a cultural celebration.

For instance, Pudhumaipithan revolutionised Tamil storytelling with his sharp social critique and modern narrative style. Sundara Ramasamy, known for his introspective novels and essays, expanded the philosophical depth of Tamil literature. Meanwhile, Jayakanthan’s fearless portrayals of marginalised communities made him one of the most influential writers

of the 20th century. The song also honours Ki. Rajanarayanan, affectionately known as ‘KiRa’, whose storytelling brought the rhythms, dialects and folklore of rural Tamil Nadu into modern literary discourse.

Early virtual reactions show that many viewers discovered these literary personalities through the song. Many comments show audiences from multiple countries wanting to know more about their works

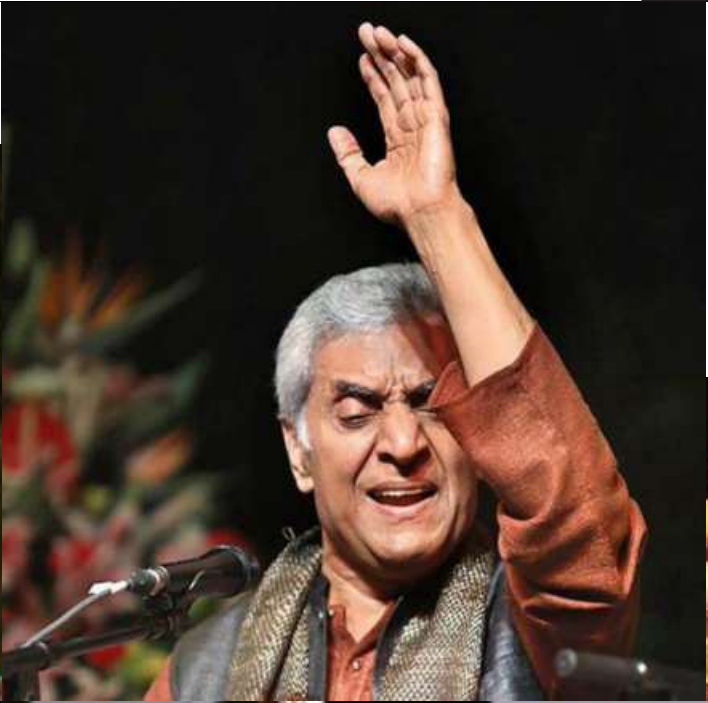
The success of the song demonstrates how digital media can revive interest in literary traditions that may otherwise remain confined to academic circles.

If the momentum continues, ‘Feel the Spark’ may mark the beginning of a trend, where the blend of music and digital media helps bring regional literary works to a global audience.

Word power Raleigh Rajan’s latest album pays tribute to well-known Tamil writers.
PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Igniting a spark

Composer Raleigh Rajan’s viral independent track ‘Feel the Spark’ generates a global interest in modern Tamil literature



Rare musical moments
(Clockwise from left) Pt. Madhup Mudgal; Pt. Tejendra Narayan Majumdar; Ramana Balachandhran; Pt. Sajan Mishra and Shashwati Mandal.
PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT AND B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM



Launched in 1947, the Shankarlal Music Festival finds its formula for continuity by embracing an ever-expanding spectrum of Indian classical traditions

Shailaja Khanna

Enjoying music is a subjective experience, shaped by many factors – familiarity with the artiste’s work, knowledge of the genre, one’s receptivity at the moment, and even the quality of the sound system. At a large music festival, the added element of being exposed to so much music in a short span of time further alters one’s perspective. The current trend in North India of scheduling concerts for only an hour or an hour and a half, followed immediately by another and then a third, is not the most conducive way to experience music. Absorbing what one has heard is an essential part of savouring it.

Pt. Madhup Mudgal created a serene ambience at his morning concert. There was no hurry, no gimmicks – just pure music. He began with raag Ahir Bhairav, a highly lyrical interpretation of the morning raag Bhairav, enriched by elements of khamach that heightened its melodious quality. The popular vilambit bandish ‘Rasiya Mharo’ was explored with gentleness. Madhup ji’s daughter, Sawani, accompanied him in the lower register, while his long-time disciple, Khushal Sharma, lent his voice in the higher notes. This contrast was particularly pleasing. One admired how the maestro resisted the current trend of prolonging the exposition to 45 minutes, as is common nowadays. Instead, he sang just enough to fully explore every nuance without unnecessary lingering. Such restraint is becoming rare among the younger generation of vocalists, many of whom feel compelled to extend the first piece in order to establish their musical credentials.

Next, he sang raag Kukulbh Bilawal, a rarity on today’s concert stage. This vilambit composition was composed by his guru Pt. Kumar Gandharva. This was followed by an unusual self-composed tarana, rendered in double speed and marked by deliberate pauses between notes. Dramatic in effect and novel in gait, the piece commanded attention. Continuing along the time scale of raags, Madhup ji then presented raag Madhmad Sarang. His tarana, set in Ek taal and again self-composed, was appealing and served as a fitting

conclusion to the concert. He was accompanied by Shambhunath Bhattacharya (tabla) and Chinmay Kolatkar (harmonium).

The second concert that captivated the audience was by Shashwati Mandal. Incidentally, she is currently training under Pt. Madhup Mudgal, despite already having a distinguished lineage of gurus. Beginning with raag Malgunji, Shashwati gradually built a deep connection with her listeners. The taans had variety and executed with remarkable breath control, including a novel closed-mouth taan. Like her guru, Shashwati also demonstrated her strength as an inspiring teacher – both her disciples who accompanied her, Swati Tiwari and Chinmayee Athale Oak, were impressive in their own right.

The festival opened with a performance by Ramana Balachandhran, accompanied by Patri Satish Kumar on the mridangam. Though many in the audience were unfamiliar with Carnatic music or the Saraswati veena, as soon as Ramana plucked the first notes on the deeply resonant strings of his instrument, a perceptible sense of awakened interest spread through the hall. He began with a brisk yet brief composition by Tyagaraja ‘Ramabhakti Samrajyamu’ in raga Shuddha Bangala, dedicated to Lord Ram, which he also sang, as is his practice. This was followed by a ragam-tanam-pallavi in raga Sarasangi – a raga closely related to Hindustani’s Nat Bhairav, and thus was instantly recognisable to many listeners. The lively sawaal-jawaab with Patri Satish Kumar was particularly entertaining. Ramana then wove in snatches of ragas Saraswati, Saramati and Maru Bihag.

In the North Indian tradition, presenting a ragamalika within the main piece is unusual, which made this moment all the more striking. Ramana concluded with Sindhu Bhairavi and the prayerful chant that has become his signature closing. Patri Satish Kumar, as always, was an equal partner in the impressive presentation, his brief solo interlude drew immense appreciation. The inclusion of Carnatic musicians in such conventional festivals is a welcome decision – this year,

flautist Shashank Subramaniam also offered his first-ever solo recital here, which was highly enjoyable. Siddharth Belamannu not only possesses a luminous voice but has established himself as a vocalist to watch out for. Beyond technique, it is his clear articulation of the lyrics that lends an edge to his singing. His rendition of raag Hameer was particularly engaging.

Other highlights of the festival: Pt. Tejendra Narayan’s alap in raga Kafi Kanhra was sublime. Sawani Shende’s relaxed interaction with her harmonium accompanist, Rahul Gole, was admirable; too often, artistes remain absorbed in their own musical vision and fail to receive a co-artist’s input. Lokesh Anand, one of the finest

shehnai players today, concluded with a lilting Banarasi *dhun*. Pt. Sajan Mishra and his son Swaraansh offered a rare Hori in raga Sindhura Kafi, known for its leisurely pace and reminiscent of an era gone by. Pt. Biswajit Roy Chaudhury’s rare Hindol Bahar, a blend of two spring ragas, was interesting.

The presence of an enthusiastic young audience at the festival augurs well for its continuity. One effective way of ensuring their participation is by coming with an unusual and diverse line-up of musicians. The organisers deserve commendation for their thoughtful artiste selection, which broadens the festival’s scope.

Sound of the season

‘Evening of Basant’ explored spring’s connect with Hindustani music

Meena Banerjee

An ‘Evening of Basant’, aesthetically showcased by the Ramakrishna Mission Institute of Culture at Vivekananda Hall, Kolkata, opened with a recital by well-known sitarist Sahana Banerjee. Interestingly, raag Shahana, after which she is named, represents the spring season, so did her chosen raag Kaushik Dhvani (also known as Bhinna Shadaj in dhrupad parlance). Quite adept at dhrupad ang baaj, thanks to her training in Senia Rampur School, Sahana’s sitar explored the depths of mandra and ati-mandra with plenty of meend-laden phrases. The power behind the sweet flow of melody was palpable, especially in the thhonk taans.

With a graceful uthaan, tabla exponent Ujjwal Bharti joined in the skilful slow and fast teental gatkaris and enhanced their appeal with excellent *jawabi sangat*. The jhala could have been more gentle.

Two well-tuned tanpuras and a soothing swarmandal transformed the ambience before Supriyo Dutta, flanked by Chiranjit Mukherjee (tabla), Debashis Adhikary (harmonium) along with Debarshi Das and Sudarshan Khatua (tanpura and vocal support) decided to delineate the all-time favourite raag, Bihag. Supriyo selected bandishes describing Holi and its hero Krishna for the ‘Basant’ evening. One was happy to note the importance accorded to the lyrics of khayal bandishes.

Supriyo’s deep, resonant voice is his biggest asset and it brought out the pathos in the Bandish ‘Kaise sukh sove’ set to Jhumra taal. The step-by-step progression facilitated ‘chit chadhi’ that lingered gracefully on the upper tonic. It led to the



antara, which spread its wings and went up to ‘Ma’. The variety of sargam, or extremely fast aakar taans’ thrilling arrival on ‘sam’, maintained its tight pattern till the last beat.

Supriyo’s impressive rhythm sense inspired Chiranjit to unleash his own skill and the duo revelled in the playful mood of ‘Kanha bhar-bhar mare pichkari’ (Teental). Short sargam pieces, in *barabar ki laya*, followed by complex and sharp taans exuded joy.

Harmonium exponent Debashish Adhikary gave his best when Sahana joined the vocalist’s to offer a Hori jugalbandi, which made for a unique finale. She began with the Khamaj phrases, laced with beautiful fillers on the harmonium. Supriyo rendition of ‘Pichkari na maro nandlala re’, set to dadra and taal pherta interludes in Keharwa was vibrant. The piece led by Supriyo and Sahana showed what two skilful musicians can do when they come together.



Flow of melody
Sahana Banerjee and (above) Supriyo Dutta.
PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

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One of post-Independence India's influential theatre figures, Amol Palekar's experimental ethos and disciplined artistry have profoundly influenced Marathi and Hindi performance traditions.

Beginning as a fine arts postgraduate at the Sir J.J. School of Art, he engaged deeply with Marathi theatre under the mentorship of the formidable Satyadev Dubey, appearing in landmark productions such as *Shantata! Court Chalu Aahe*, *Hayavadana*, and *Adhe Adhure*.

In 1972, Palekar founded his own troupe, Aniket, to champion unconventional projects – directing and acting in plays such as *Gochi*, the procession-style *Juloos* and *Chal Re Bhoplya Tunuk Tunuk*, often staged in open spaces or non-traditional venues to disrupt passive spectatorship and bring theatre closer to everyday realities.

Preparing for one more comeback under the direction of his doughty partner Sandhya Gokhale, the veteran speaks about how his work has long embodied the abiding power of subtle revolution.

Edited excerpts from an interview:

Question: How do you view META's (Mahindra Excellence in Theatre Awards) Lifetime Achievement award? Is the recognition delayed? Has your film career in any way overshadowed your contribution to theatre?

Answer: Any award, to my mind, is a validation that what one has pursued over decades has had artistic and social relevance. I accept this award with a certain perspective. As Rabindranath Tagore wrote, "I slept and dreamt that life was joy; I awoke and saw that life was service; I acted and behold, service was joy." In that sense, the work itself has always been its own reward. The honour, whenever it comes, is only incidental. Yes, in my case, the recognition is delayed. One has seen many mediocre practitioners receiving honours very early in their careers. I neither sought validation nor solicited recognition. Unfortunately, for a larger public, my identity has been largely defined by my film career and the popular image associated with it. That visibility has, in a way,

Amol Palekar, who recently received META's Lifetime Achievement Award, on how he neither aspired to act nor to direct

overshadowed my work in visual arts and theatre, which was always very fulfilling.

Q: It seems that, much like painting, your involvement in theatre happened unexpectedly. Could you describe how Satyadev Dubey discovered you?

A: My entry into theatre was an accident. I neither aspired to act nor to direct; it was never a conscious pursuit. My association with Satyadev Dubey began almost incidentally, when he chose me for my first acting assignment in *Chup Court Chalu Hain*. That decision entirely came from his instinct and his faith in me. What that faith did was crucial. It gave me a sense of confidence I did not know I possessed. Under his guidance, I began to discover not just the craft of theatre, but also my own creative instincts. What started as an accident gradually evolved into a deeply fulfilling artistic journey, where I found myself growing, experimenting and flourishing both creatively and intellectually.

Q: There is flair, and then there is technique. In your case, how do the two work as actor and director?

A: Flair, by itself, can be impulsive and fleeting; technique can become rigid and lifeless. As an actor and director, I have always tried to negotiate a space where instinct is



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informed by craft, and craft remains alive through instinct. It is in that dialogue between the two that meaningful theatre, for me, begins to emerge.

Q: Tell us about the role of Dubey and Sombhu Mitra in shaping your career on stage.

A: Dubey prepared me holistically. With him, theatre was never fragmented into isolated departments. He made me understand the significance of every element on the proscenium – light, music, space design. More importantly, he taught me how to interpret a text and translate that interpretation into a coherent theatrical experience. With Sombhu da, my learning was of a different order. Watching him, one understood how an actor can draw

the audience into the magic of illusion. Between the two, I came to understand the relationship between flair and technique. Technique gives the actor and director their foundation, the grammar and discipline of the craft. But it is flair that animates it, that allows the work to breathe and reach the audience.

Q: How did painting influence your theatre choices, and how did theatre practice contribute to performing for the camera?

A: My approach has always been minimalist. In painting, I was deeply aware of the areas I chose to leave unpainted; the white spaces that remain untouched. Those spaces are not accidental; they are deliberate. The same sensibility informed my theatre – the use of silence, of pauses, of restraint. Painting also



Multifaceted Amol Palekar; (Above) with Amrish Puri and Sunila Pradhan during the rehearsal of Girish Karnad's *Hayavadana*. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

shaped my perspective of theatre as a visual medium. My understanding of composition, lighting, colour palette and texture began to influence how I visualised and staged my plays, and later, my films. Lighting, especially, became a crucial element, not just to illuminate, but to create mood and structure meaning.

At the same time, theatre contributed significantly to my work in front of the camera. It instilled a sense of rhythm, timing, and discipline. On stage, one learns projection; for the camera, one learns containment. Theatre taught me control, while painting expanded my visual imagination – the two constantly informing each other.

Q: Despite being an outsider and achieving success, you chose not to fully embrace mainstream theatre. How did you manage the balance between creative satisfaction and commercial success?

A: I have always had a certain aversion to what is broadly called commercial theatre. It was not a moral position so much as an aesthetic one. The subjects, the performances, even the set design, often did not appeal to me. I was always searching for a path less travelled, something that would challenge me creatively rather than reassure me with familiarity. My work in films, in a way, made that

independence possible. But even within cinema, I was careful about my choices. After the early success of three silver jubilee films as a debut actor, I consciously moved towards roles that were unexpected, even negative, simply to avoid being trapped in an image.

Q: You've been a vocal advocate against pre-censorship. What changes have you seen in censorship practices over the decades, and where do we stand today?

A: The fundamental thrust behind censorship is to interfere with artistic expression. The mechanisms may evolve, the language may shift, but the impulse to control what is expressed persists. What has changed more noticeably is the nature of that control. Increasingly, the prevailing political ideology of the time begins to dictate what is permissible. We stand at a point where the need to safeguard artistic freedom is more urgent than ever. Beyond formal state mechanisms like censor boards, there are also sections of society that are mobilised to protest against dissent, where the claim of "hurt sentiments" becomes a convenient and frequently used pretext. Theatre, by its very nature, engages directly with society; it provokes, reflects, and questions. To impose pre-censorship on such a medium is to diminish its very purpose.

Q: You took a long break from theatre before returning with *Kusur*? Will we see one more comeback?

A: I do intend to return, later this year, with a fascinating English play written and directed by Sandhya Gokhale. Besides producing, I will also be acting in it. At my age, even a small challenge assumes significance. It demands a different kind of preparation, both physical and mental. But that is precisely what keeps the engagement alive... the need to test oneself, to step into something unfamiliar once again. Let us see how I can meet that challenge.

When K-Pop wave hit Hollywood

‘Golden’ makes history – the first K-Pop number to win an Oscar

Rachel Rhine

The Academy Awards rarely intersect with the world of Korean pop music. This year, however, that boundary shifted decisively when ‘Golden,’ from *K-Pop Demon Hunters*, won the Oscar for Best Original Song, becoming the first K-pop track to receive the honour.

At first glance, the pairing feels unusual. The Oscars have traditionally celebrated film music rooted in Broadway-style ballads, orchestral themes or singer-songwriter compositions. A contemporary Korean pop track emerging from an animated fantasy about idol-heroes is not the most predictable addition to that lineage. Yet the trajectory of ‘Golden’ suggests how dramatically the global music landscape has changed.

In *KPop Demon Hunters*, the song arrives at the emotional centre of the film. Directed by Maggie Kang and Chris Appelhans, the animated musical follows three globally adored idols who secretly defend the world from supernatural forces. Publicly, they perform as the chart-topping girl group Huntrix. Privately, they wage a battle against demons threatening humanity. The premise carries the heightened energy of pop spectacle, but it is also a story about responsibility, identity and the complicated relationship between artistes and their audiences.

‘Golden’ accompanies one of the film’s defining moments,



Centre-stage moment (from left) Joong Gyu Kwak, Mark Sonnenblick, EJAE, Hee Dong Nam, and Yu Han Lee at the Governor's Ball after the Oscars; and (below); Rei Ami, EJAE, and Audrey Nuna at the Oscars. PHOTOS: AP

when the characters confront both the weight of their secret mission and the expectations placed upon them as performers. Sung by EJAE, Audrey Nuna and Rei Ami, who provide the singing voices for the fictional trio, the track unfolds with a gradual build: restrained verses give way to a chorus that expands outward with cinematic scale. Its lyrics move fluidly between English and Korean, reflecting the linguistic hybridity that has become increasingly common with contemporary K-pop.

The creative team behind the song reflects a similarly international collaboration. EJAE wrote the track alongside Mark Sonnenblick and a group of Korean composers and lyricists that includes Teddy Park, a producer whose influence on modern Korean pop is difficult to overstate. Park's involvement lends the song a sonic lineage that traces back through two decades of the genre's evolution, even as the track functions within the narrative framework of a film musical.

Outside the film, ‘Golden’ quickly proved capable of standing on its own. The track entered the Billboard Hot 100 and gained traction across global streaming platforms, suggesting that its appeal

extended beyond the context of the movie. Like many successful K-pop releases, the song thrives on a combination of melodic immediacy, polished production and performance-driven energy. Its awards trajectory has been equally remarkable. Earlier this year, ‘Golden’ won Best Song Written for Visual Media at the Grammy Awards, becoming the first K-pop song to secure a Grammy. Within months, the track added an Oscar to that list,



marking a rare moment when both the music and film industries converged in recognising the same piece of work.

The Oscars ceremony itself reflected that convergence. The live performance of ‘Golden’ brought tightly choreographed staging and dramatic visual design to the Academy's stage, briefly transforming the awards show into something resembling a K-pop concert. It was a striking contrast to the restrained performances that often define the category. The success of the song also arrives within the wider context of the Korean Wave or Hallyu, which has steadily reshaped global entertainment. Korean cinema, television dramas and pop music have all expanded far beyond their original audiences over the past decade. Films such as *Parasite* demonstrated that Korean storytelling could command the highest honours in cinema, while K-pop artistes have cultivated fan communities that span continents.

For K-pop, the moment feels less like a sudden breakthrough than the formal recognition of something that has been unfolding for years. The audience was already global. The awards, it seems, are finally beginning to reflect that reality.

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